

in-ear earphones in the same price range skip out on adding high-quality CODECs to their products, so having this is great!

PERFORMANCE

Nothing Ear (a) lost the most ground in terms of their performance. At the Digit Test Centre, we compare every piece of audio equipment that comes in against the flat benchmark sound signature recorded by us using Pink Noise. And, due to their bass-forward sound signature, the Nothing Ear (a) lost a fair bit of points in our scoring. As you can see below, the sound signature of Nothing Ear (a) has a lot of bass extension, and its over-emphasised nature makes the sound muddy and boomy. It is not as bad as what we experienced in the Moto Buds Plus, but it does lean into the mids and highs. There is detail in the sound; however, in certain specific scenarios, like action sequences in movies, dialogues might get muffled a little bit.

In tracks like Uptown Funk by Bruno Mars, you will enjoy this extended bass response, especially if you are someone who considers themselves a “bass-head”. For others, you might feel that the bass is a bit too overwhelming out of the box. Surprisingly, the bass enhance mode tamed it down quite a bit. And, if you are someone who is not comfortable working with the inbuilt EQ, then you would definitely be able to manage with this mode turned on.

But, if you are planning to tinker with the EQ, then I would recommend turning the bass down by almost half in the simple EQ mode. But, then again, that is my preference. The only word of caution that I would like to give you is the bass response is more than what you would expect, so tread with caution. Bass lovers, go all in.

When pitted against similarly priced offerings like the Sony WF-C700N and the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW, these in-ear earphones pale in comparison to the much more well-rounded sound of the other two buds. You can see the difference in the overall consistency and balance in the sound signature of the other two buds.

Keep in mind that the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW lack a lot of features that the Nothing Ear (a) comes packing with, and

the Sony WF-C700N will mostly be on the pricier side during the sale season. But the Sonys do make for a strong case for themselves. And, if you are looking at the Nothing Ear (2024), out of the box, these in-ear earphones pale in comparison, but with some changes in the EQ, you will definitely get pretty close in terms of performance. So, you can save a buck or two with these in-ear earphones over the Nothing Ear (2024).

Coming to the ANC and transparency mode. The tone was set by the Nothing Ear (2024) when it came to ANC performance. I went in with no bias in my head but quickly realised that the ANC performance of these in-ear earphones is almost the same as that of the Nothing Ear (2024). While for those in-ear earphones that are priced slightly higher, and suffer a lot due to the dip in the ANC performance, these in-ear earphones do not get penalised as much.

When ANC is turned on and set to max, you will not hear almost any low-end sounds, including ones like the humming of ACs or the ambient humming sounds in aircraft. When faced with more challenging scenarios where the sound coming in is more irregular, for example, in traffic or when someone is typing on a loud keyboard around you, these in-ear earphones tend to struggle a bit. You will get irregular spikes in the sound levels, which I believe can be easily polished out with a firmware update. Let's hope for the best here.

The microphones on these in-ear earphones also hold their own when it comes to indoor and relatively silent spaces. The clear voice tech that Nothing has packed in ensures that your voice goes through clearly. In noisy environments, the in-ear earphones tend to struggle a little bit, letting in some of the ambient noise; however, the performance was passable overall.

BATTERY LIFE

The battery life of the Nothing Ear (a) pack is also something that I was pleasantly surprised with. In my tests, with ANC on and volume set to 50 per cent, these in-ear earphones were able to manage a total battery life of 5 hours and 15 minutes, with the case providing for four more rounds of charging. This brings up the battery life of

these in-ear earphones up to 21 hours in total with some juice left in the case.

This gives them a lead over the Sony WF-C700N and the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW, which lasted for 14 hours and 18 hours, respectively. And, when you are out of charge, you can get up to 10 hours of playback in just 10 minutes of charge, as claimed by the brand. So, that is something to definitely keep in mind when you are making your purchase decision.

VERDICT

Nothing Ear (a) makes for a compelling option for people looking for a pair of TWS in-ear earphones with ample, well-implemented features, and if you are a fan of bass-heavy music or if you are someone who is willing to play around with the EQ to ensure that you get the sound that you desire. Out of the box, their sound is bass-heavy, and might not appeal to the purists, but the EQ in the Nothing X app, and the overall customisation experience provided by the app, definitely make up for all the lost ground.

If you are looking for alternatives, then the Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW and the Sony WF-C700N are your best bets. Both are priced similarly to the Nothing Ear (a). The Audio-Technica ATH-SQ1TW offer much better sound out of the box, but they trade out a lot of features that you get with the Nothing Ear (a). The Sony WF-C700N, offer similar sound out of the box and features. With those earbuds, the only place where you would be left in splits would be the aesthetics. And, that is up to you.

Coming to their pricier cousins, the Nothing Ear (2024), you get the extra bit for which you would pay. So, if you have the budget, go for them over the Nothing Ear (a). However, read our review before doing it!

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Driver: 11 mm dynamic driver | Battery Capacity: 46 mAh (Earbuds), 500 mAh (Case) | ANC: Up to 45 dB | Bluetooth: V5.3 | CODECs: AAC, SBC, LDAC | Nothing X App Support: Yes | Battery Life: Up to 42.5 hours with case (ANC off)

CONTACT

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